The Foundation
0%

Module 1: QUICK START (...
1.1 What You Need (5 Min Set...
1.2 Your First Folder
1.3 How to Structure Any Pro...

Module 2: WHY THIS WO...
2.1 Video Text Guide (Series ...
2.2 One Line of Python Trigge...
2.3 How a 1953 Word Game E...
2.4 The Ladder That Explains ...
2.5 Clawdbot (Moltbot) Has 1...
2.6 Video as Code: My AI Ani...
2.7 From Nazi Psychology to ...

Module 3: FOLDER ARCHI...
3.1 The Full Walkthrough (23 ...
3.2 Customizing for Your Use ...
3.3 Common Mistakes and H...

# 4.1: Install and First Use

24:33

## What You'll Get From This

All three Claude interfaces installed and working on your machine. A clear sense of when to use which one. And your first real task run on your own files.

## Video: Session 1 — Installing Claude Desktop and Claude Code

This is the first of five sessions. Each one builds on the last and each one ends with something on your computer that was not there before. Here is the full series:

**Session 1 (this lesson):** Install all three interfaces. Understand when to use which.

**Session 2 (4.2):** Claude Code in practice. The real power and workflow.

**Session 3 (4.3):** Claude Desktop as a thinking partner. More than just generating stuff.

4.1: Install and First Use

4.2: Claude Code in Practice

4.3: Claude Desktop as a Thin...

4.4 Making Claude Understan...

4.5: Where This Goes

SECTION 5: WHERE TO G...

**Session 5 (4.5):** Where all of this goes. The file architecture system and what comes next.

---

## The Lesson

### How most people use Claude

Most people use Claude like a search engine that writes better sentences. You type a question, you get an answer, you copy and paste it somewhere. That works. But it is like using a car to check the mailbox. The car can take you across the country. You just have not left the driveway yet.

Today we leave the driveway.

---

### Three interfaces, one model

This is the thing most people miss. There are three ways to use Claude, and they are not three different AIs. It is one model with three different ways to access it. The difference is what each interface lets that model see and do.

### Claude Desktop (or claude.ai)

The downloaded app or the website. A conversational tool. Great for planning, thinking through ideas, getting answers, building drafts. But there is a limit to what it can do at scale. It cannot see your files directly. It cannot run code. It cannot edit anything in your project. Everything goes through copy, paste, or uploads.

That is not because the model is limited. The model is extremely powerful. The problem is the interface. It just cannot reach your stuff. If you have ever felt like Claude kind of gets it but not quite, it is probably because you are working from a pasted excerpt instead of your actual project.

### Claude Code in VS Code

You describe what you need and it works directly within the files.

VS Code (Visual Studio Code) is a coding environment made by Microsoft. If you have never opened it, do not worry. It is simpler than it looks and we will walk through setup. You do not need to know how to code. VS Code just lets you see your folders as a file tree and open documents without clicking through layers of windows.

If you are familiar with Cursor, Windsurf, Copilot, or Antigravity, those are all built on top of VS Code. They support different models and different processes. Some use Claude, some do not. This course is specifically for Claude's tools inside the Anthropic environment.

## Claude Code in the terminal

The same engine under the hood, just a different wrapper. The terminal version is better for when your work does not live in a code project. Processing a folder of documents. Managing files. Cleaning up your downloads folder. Anything where you just need Claude to read a bunch of files and do something with them.

You do not need the terminal version to get value from this course. But if you are already comfortable in the terminal, it is faster for some jobs.

---

## The real difference

The desktop is a conversation layer. VS Code is an editor layer. The terminal is a command line layer. Same brain behind all three.

Interface Best for Can see your files? Can edit your files? Claude Desktop / claude.ai Thinking, planning, quick questions, drafting Only if you upload them No Claude Code in VS Code Building, editing, working inside a project Yes, automatically Yes Claude Code in terminal File processing, quick tasks, non-code projects Yes, in the current folder Yes

---

**Here is the same task across all three:**

**In Claude Desktop:** You want to summarize a document. You go find the file on your computer. You upload it. You type "Summarize this PDF and suggest three improvements." Claude processes it and gives you a good answer. Works fine. But you had to go find the file, upload it, and then the summary lives in the chat. If you want it in a file, you copy and paste it somewhere.

**In VS Code:** You open the folder where the document lives. You type "Summarize python breakdown PDF and suggest three improvements." Claude immediately knows which file you mean because it can see the folder. It reads the file, gives you the summary, and can write the output directly to a new file in the same folder. One less step. No uploading. No copy-paste.

**In the terminal:** You open a terminal in the folder, type `claude`, and give the same instruction. Same result as VS Code, just a different window. Better for quick one-off tasks where you do not need to see the file tree.

The model gives the same quality answer in all three. The difference is how much manual work you do around it.

---

## Installing everything

Let's get all three working.

### Step 1: Claude Desktop

If you do not have it already:

Go to claude.ai/download and download the app for your OS (Mac or Windows). Install it. Sign in with your Claude account.

That is it. You now have the conversational interface.

### Step 2: Node.js

You need Node.js before you can install Claude Code. Node.js lets you run JavaScript on your computer and gives you access

To verify it worked, open your terminal and type:

```
node --version
```

If you see a version number, you are good.

### Step 3: Claude Code (terminal)

With Node.js installed, run this command in your terminal:

```
npm install -g @anthropic-ai/claude-code
```

Once it finishes, you can type `claude` in any folder and Claude Code will launch.

### Step 4: Claude Code in VS Code

First, install VS Code if you do not have it:

Go to code.visualstudio.com and download it. Install it. Open it.

Then install the Claude Code extension:

1. In VS Code, look for the **Extensions** icon in the left sidebar (the one with squares, one slightly tilted). Or press `Ctrl+Shift+X` (Windows/Linux) or `Cmd+Shift+X` (Mac).
2. Search for "**Claude Code**"
3. Click the blue **Install** button
4. You may need to restart VS Code

You should now see the Claude Code icon in your sidebar. Click on any file to open a page, then the Claude panel will be available.

the extension to activate. Also, VS Code has its own built-in chat that is separate from Claude Code. Make sure you are using the Claude Code extension, not the VS Code native chat.

---

## Troubleshooting

🔴 **"npm: command not found"** — Node.js did not install correctly. Close your terminal completely, reopen it, and try again. If it still fails, reinstall Node.js.

🔴 **"Permission denied" during npm install** — On Mac/Linux, try:
`sudo npm install -g @anthropic-ai/claude-code`

🔴 **Claude Code launches but asks for authentication** — Follow the link it gives you to sign in. You need a Pro or Max subscription.

🔴 **VS Code extension does not show Claude panel** — Make sure you clicked Install, restarted VS Code, and have a file open. Check that you are using the Claude Code extension, not VS Code's built-in chat.

If you get stuck on any of this, post in the community or Discord with your OS and the error message. Someone has hit the same wall.

---

## Your first real task

This is not just a lecture. You should walk away with something done.

Pick one thing from your own work. A document, a report, a file you have been meaning to process. Put it in a folder.

1. Try it in Claude Desktop: upload the file, ask Claude to summarize it or answer questions about it.
2. Try it in VS Code: open the folder, ask Claude Code the same thing. Notice that you did not upload anything. It just read the file.

This exercise is not about getting a perfect answer. It is about feeling the difference between pasting context into Claude and having Claude go to where the context already lives.

---

## Why this matters for everything that comes next

In **Section 1**, you set up a folder with three files and pasted context into Claude or loaded it into a Project. That worked. But it was manual.

Claude Code makes the folder architecture from **Section 3** fully operational. Your CLAUDE.md, your context files, your workspaces, your routing table. Claude Code reads all of it live. It navigates between workspaces, loads the right context, follows the routing table, and works inside your file system. The folder becomes the app. Claude Code is the thing that runs it.

Sessions 2 through 5 build on this. We go from installation to real workflows, thinking partnerships, project-level understanding, and the full architecture. But it all starts with having these three tools working on your machine.

---

### Resources

- **Claude Desktop**
- **Node.js**
- **VS Code**
- **Claude Code Install:** `npm install -g @anthropic-ai/claude-code`

---

### Go Deeper

- If you have not set up your folder structure yet, go back to **1.2: Your First Folder** for the quick version or **3.1: The Full**

- Already comfortable with Claude Code? **4.2: Claude Code in Practice** is the next session, showing you the real power and workflow.
- Want to understand the model behind all three interfaces? **2.2: One Line of Python Triggers 12,000 Lines of Code** traces what happens underneath when you type a command.

---

## Next Up: 4.2 Claude Code in Practice

You have the tools installed. Next session shows you the real power: how to actually work with Claude Code on a real project, the workflow that makes it useful, and the things you can do that are impossible in the chat interface.

Matthew Creamer
24d • Lesson Check-Ins

### Foundations 4.1 Check-In

First session done. Vote below, then drop your OS and any issues you hit in the comments. If you got stuck, someone

Poll 103 members have voted

40 47 New comment 1h ago